Amina T. Mambuay

Amina T. Mambuay (née **Tominaman**) is a pioneering Filipino Muslim peacebuilder, educator, and the first Maranao woman to become an internationally certified trainer with the Center for Nonviolent Communication (CNVC). Born and raised in Marawi City, Mambuay has spent over two decades championing interfaith dialogue, compassionate communication, and social healing across the Philippines and internationally. She holds the distinction of being the only CNVC-certified trainer in the Philippines, a credential she earned in 2016 after nearly a decade of dedicated practice and training. Her work bridges the deeply personal practice of nonviolent communication with broader peacebuilding efforts in Mindanao, a region historically marked by Muslim-Christian conflict and the devastating 2017 Marawi siege. Through her leadership of Kalilintad Pilipinas Inc. and her role as Muslim Coordinator for the Silsilah Forum in Cagayan de Oro, Mambuay has touched thousands of lives, offering tools for empathy, conflict transformation, and reconciliation. Her family's collective advocacy earned them the prestigious Jollibee Family Values Award, recognizing their commitment to fostering unity across religious divides.

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Early Life and Background

Amina Tominaman was born and raised in Marawi City, the capital of Lanao del Sur province in Mindanao and known as the "Islamic City of Marawi." She comes from a Muslim-Maranao family, belonging to the Maranao people—the largest Muslim ethnolinguistic group in the Philippines, whose name literally means "people of the lake" in reference to Lake Lanao. The Maranao community, numbering over 1.4 million, is renowned for its rich cultural heritage, including the UNESCO-recognized Darangen epic, intricate okir woodcarvings, and the distinctive torogan royal houses.

Growing up in Marawi during a period of ongoing Muslim-Christian tensions in Mindanao, Mambuay witnessed firsthand the cycles of conflict, discrimination, and misunderstanding that plagued her homeland. The Maranao people had long resisted colonial powers—from Spanish conquistadors to American forces—and maintained a

strong sense of cultural identity and Islamic faith despite centuries of external pressure. This historical context of resistance and marginalization would later inform Mambuay's deep commitment to peacebuilding and dialogue.

Her upbringing in a predominantly Muslim city that nonetheless housed Christians and other faiths gave her early exposure to the possibilities of interfaith coexistence, even as broader societal forces worked against it. Marawi, situated on the shores of Lake Lanao at an elevation that provides a cooler climate than surrounding areas, served as both a center of Islamic learning and a flashpoint for broader conflicts over land rights, political representation, and religious identity in Mindanao.

Education

Mambuay pursued higher education at Ateneo de Cagayan University, now known as Xavier University, one of Mindanao's premier Catholic institutions located in Cagayan de Oro City. There she earned a Bachelor of Arts degree in Philippine Studies, followed by a Master of Arts in Sociology-Anthropology. Her choice to study at a Catholic university as a Muslim woman demonstrated an early openness to crossing religious boundaries—a theme that would define her life's work.

Her academic training in sociology and anthropology equipped her with analytical frameworks for understanding the complex social dynamics, cultural traditions, and structural inequalities that characterized Muslim-Christian relations in Mindanao. The interdisciplinary nature of her studies allowed her to examine Philippine society from multiple angles, considering historical legacies, cultural practices, power structures, and identity formation.

This educational foundation proved invaluable when she later began working in research and education, as it gave her the tools to both analyze conflict systematically and communicate insights across different audiences. Her time at Xavier University also exposed her to progressive Catholic thought on interfaith dialogue, particularly ideas emerging from the Second Vatican Council's declaration Nostra Aetate, which encouraged respectful engagement with other religions.

Amina T. Mambuay



Born	Amina Tominaman Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao
Education	Bachelor of Arts in Philippine Studies Master of Arts in Sociology-Anthropology Ateneo de Cagayan University (Xavier University)
Occupation	Nonviolent Communication Trainer Peacebuilder Interfaith Dialogue Facilitator Educator
Known for	First and only internationally certified NVC trainer in the Philippines First Maranao CNVC-certified trainer Interfaith dialogue advocacy Founder, Kalilintad Pilipinas Inc.
Spouse	Nathaniel Mambuay
Children	Including Lara Mambuay and Sarah Adrianne Mambuay
Awards	Jollibee Family Values Award

Professional Career

Academic and Research Work

After completing her education, Mambuay worked as a researcher at Xavier University, where she explored issues confronting Muslims and Lumad (indigenous) communities in Mindanao. Her research delved into the historical grievances, economic disparities, and social marginalization faced by these communities, providing empirical documentation of patterns of discrimination and structural inequality.

From June 1990 to May 1995, she served as a college instructor at Mindanao State University (MSU) in Marawi City, one of the country's premier institutions for higher education serving Muslim Filipinos. MSU's main campus in Marawi was established in 1961 to address the educational needs of Muslim communities in Mindanao and promote understanding between Muslims and Christians. Teaching at MSU allowed Mambuay to directly influence the next generation of Maranao leaders and professionals, sharing both academic knowledge and her growing insights about peaceful coexistence.

However, the late 1990s brought significant challenges. Mambuay and her husband Nathaniel Mambuay, also a Muslim-Maranao, faced severe employment discrimination in the private sector. As Nathaniel recounted, finding jobs as Muslims proved extremely difficult: "Sa private sector, napakahirap ng employment para sa isang Muslim. Sa Iligan maswerte na kung may isang Muslim na naka-employ sa isang kumpanya" (In the private sector, employment for a Muslim is very difficult. In Iligan you're lucky if even one Muslim is employed in a company). These personal experiences of marginalization deepened their resolve to work toward greater understanding and equality.

Discovery of Nonviolent Communication

Mambuay's transformative encounter with Nonviolent Communication came through an unexpected source—a Catholic nun friend who gave her a copy of Marshall Rosenberg's seminal book, "Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Life." Rosenberg, an American psychologist who developed NVC in the 1960s and 1970s, created a communication approach based on empathy, honesty, and compassionate connection. His work emerged from his own experiences with violence and antisemitism growing up in Detroit, and he spent decades teaching NVC as a tool for reconciliation in conflict zones worldwide.

The book resonated deeply with Mambuay, offering a practical methodology for the kind of understanding and peace she sought. In 2007, another friend—this time a priest—recommended her for NVC training in Ruhpolding, Germany. This international training proved to be a turning point in her life. The intensive workshop exposed her to practitioners from diverse backgrounds and conflict zones, showing her that the principles of empathic listening and compassionate communication could transcend cultural and religious boundaries.

Mambuay immediately recognized NVC's potential for addressing the deep-seated conflicts in Mindanao. As she later explained, "NVC promotes better relations and understanding between Muslims, Christians, and people of other living faiths. It is a calling and a mission, because we work as volunteers. And I am happy with our choice. It meets our desire to contribute to the well-being of others and to contribute to peace and understanding."

Her husband Nathaniel joined her in this advocacy the same year, and together they began introducing NVC to various sectors in Philippine society, from educational institutions to faith communities to conflict-affected areas. Even before earning official certification, Mambuay was already conducting workshops and training sessions, determined to share these transformative tools with her community.

Certification and Expertise Development

Mambuay's journey toward CNVC certification was long and rigorous. The certification process through the Center for Nonviolent Communication has been compared to an independent study master's degree program in its depth and requirements. Candidates must demonstrate extensive practice, undergo multiple levels of training, receive assessments from certified trainers, and show competency in teaching NVC to diverse audiences.

In 2016, after nearly a decade of dedicated study and practice, Mambuay became a certified trainer—the first Maranao and the first Muslim-Filipino to achieve this distinction, and the only certified NVC trainer in the entire Philippines. This milestone reflected not just her personal mastery of the methodology but also her pioneering role in bringing systematic communication training to Filipino communities.

The certification was supported by visits from German NVC trainers to the Philippines. In the summer of 2015, four German certified trainers—Gitta Zimmermann, Klaus Karstadt, Esther Gerdts, and Friederike Kahlau-Karstadt—conducted multiple workshops across the Philippines, working alongside Mambuay and her husband. These workshops reached diverse audiences: prisoners and military chaplains in Tagaytay, children in conflict with the law at the Cebu City Minor Dorm, BJMP personnel and social workers, University of San Carlos staff, and religious groups at the Cebu Seminary. The German trainers' visit provided crucial endorsement for the continued promotion of NVC in the Philippines and supported Mambuay's path to certification.

As a certified trainer, Mambuay's expertise spans multiple areas: Education, Mind-Body-Spirit integration, Parenting and Family dynamics, Conflict Resolution, and Social Change. She leads transformative workshops and trainings both locally and internationally, offering empathy sessions grounded in NVC principles. Her work focuses particularly on reducing prejudice and bias among people of different faiths and empowering youth as agents of change.

Institutional Contributions and Leadership

Kalilintad Pilipinas Inc.

In 2010, witnessing the profound suffering caused by calamities and the ongoing animosities between Muslims and Christians in Mindanao, Mambuay and her family established Kalilintad Pilipinas Inc., a non-governmental organization dedicated to education and peacebuilding. The organization's founding reflected the family's belief that proper education for children offered the greatest hope for peace—if not in the present generation, then for future ones.

Kalilintad Pilipinas runs a shelter for students from grades 4 through 8, providing housing, education, and care for children who would otherwise lack access to schooling. At its peak, the shelter housed 17 students—six Muslims and nine Christians—many of them orphans or from impoverished families whose parents could not afford to send them to school. This intentional mixing of Muslim and Christian children under one roof embodied the organization's commitment to building bridges across religious divides from an early age.

Beyond the educational shelter, the organization conducts community outreach including distribution of slippers and school supplies to children in remote areas, medical missions, and relief goods for indigent families. As Mambuay explained to her own children when starting these initiatives: "Kasi nakita namin yung mga bata especially yung nakatira sa liblib, pumapasok sa school walang tsinelas, tapos yung lagayan ng school materials nila plastic bag... Sabi ko sa mga anak ko baka pwede tayo makabigay kahit konting tulong" (We saw children, especially those living in remote areas, going to school without slippers, and their school materials were kept in plastic bags... I told my children maybe we could give even a little help).

The family eventually relocated from Marawi to Misamis Oriental to continue this work, establishing their permanent residence there while maintaining connections to their Maranao homeland.

Silsilah Forum Cagayan de Oro

Mambuay serves as the Muslim Coordinator for Silsilah Forum Cagayan de Oro, a local chapter of the broader Silsilah Dialogue Movement. Silsilah, which means "chain," "bond," or "family tree" in Arabic, was founded in 1984 by Italian PIME missionary Fr. Sebastiano D'Ambra in Zamboanga City as an autonomous movement for dialogue formed by Christians and Muslims. The movement envisions "a life-in-dialogue for all Muslims, Christians and peoples of other living faiths in respect, trust and love for one another."

The Silsilah Movement emerged in response to the violent conflicts in Mindanao, including clashes between the Moro National Liberation Front and Philippine military forces. Fr. D'Ambra, who studied Islam and Arabic in Rome before returning to the Philippines, created Silsilah as a "common house" where people of all faiths could meet as equals. The movement emphasizes dialogue not just as conversation but as a spirituality—dialogue with God, with oneself, with others, and with creation.

As Muslim Coordinator in Cagayan de Oro, Mambuay helps lead the local Silsilah Forum, organizing activities that promote friendship and mutual trust between Christians and Muslims. These include workshops, seminars, community gatherings, and participation in the annual World Interfaith Harmony Week celebrated each February. Silsilah Forum groups focus on building grassroots relationships that can withstand political tensions and violent provocations.

The movement's work proved particularly crucial during the 2013 Zamboanga siege when MNLF forces attacked the city. The Interfaith Council of Leaders of Silsilah appeared on television to announce that the siege was not a religious war, helping to prevent broader Muslim-Christian violence. A former MNLF commander later told Fr. D'Ambra that seeing this appeal on television convinced him to cancel a planned rebel offensive in the city.

Mambuay's role integrates her NVC expertise with Silsilah's dialogue methodology, offering communication tools that help participants move beyond talking about peace to actually practicing it in their daily interactions.

Interfaith Forum for Peace and Harmony

Mambuay is also an active member of the Interfaith Forum for Peace and Harmony in Cagayan de Oro, where she regularly facilitates trainings, talks, and community engagements that promote understanding across cultures and religions, both locally and internationally. This forum brings together leaders from different faith traditions to address shared concerns and build collaborative responses to social challenges.

Her involvement in multiple interfaith organizations reflects a strategic approach to peacebuilding—working through different networks and platforms to reach diverse audiences and create multiple points of connection between communities. Where Silsilah focuses specifically on Muslim-Christian dialogue rooted in spiritual practice, the Interfaith Forum for Peace and Harmony encompasses a broader range of religious traditions and emphasizes concrete collaborative action on social issues.

In 2022, Mambuay served as a resource person for the Interfaith Cooperation Forum's five-day in-person Training of Trainers on Nonviolent Communication, held in Dumaguete City. She co-facilitated alongside her daughter Lara Mambuay, demonstrating how the family's commitment to NVC has extended across generations. Nine participants from four Asian countries—Bangladesh, Philippines, Timor-Leste, and Nepal—attended the training, representing Muslim, Christian, and Hindu traditions. The training covered NVC components and principles, empathy exercises, receiving difficult messages, and the "13 NVC Dance Steps" for navigating challenging conversations.

Navigating the Marawi Siege

The 2017 Marawi siege represented one of the darkest chapters in recent Philippine history and had profound implications for Mambuay's work and identity as a Maranao peacebuilder. On May 23, 2017, militants affiliated with the Islamic State—primarily from the Maute Group and Abu Sayyaf—attacked Marawi City in an attempt to establish a caliphate in Southeast Asia. The Philippine military's response involved five months of intense urban warfare, aerial bombardment, and ground combat that left the city in ruins.

The siege displaced over 360,000 people from Marawi and surrounding areas, killed more than 1,200 people (including civilians, soldiers, and militants), and destroyed approximately 20% of the city's infrastructure. Entire neighborhoods were reduced to rubble. The city where Mambuay was born and raised—the center of Maranao culture and Islamic learning—became a symbol of the violent extremism that she had spent years working to prevent.

For Mambuay and the broader Maranao community, the siege was a profound trauma. The Maute brothers who led the attack were themselves Maranaos from a wealthy, politically connected family in Butig, Lanao del Sur. Their radicalization and the participation of other young Maranaos in the siege raised painful questions about what had failed in Maranao society and how extremist ideologies had taken root among the youth.

In the aftermath of the siege, all mayors of Lanao del Sur issued a manifesto labeling the Maute Group and its sympathizers as "enemies of the Maranao people," attempting to distance the broader community from the extremists. Yet the damage to Marawi's infrastructure and social fabric—not to mention the stigmatization of Muslims and Maranaos in national discourse—created enormous challenges for reconstruction and reconciliation.

During the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, Mambuay gave an interview reflecting on how the Ramadan holy month was being observed amid both the pandemic and the lingering effects of the 2017 siege. She emphasized the resilience of the Muslim community: "I am one with all those observing the Holy month of Ramadan. I am hopeful that with our prayers, we will be able to face the challenges brought about by the COVID-19 pandemic, and other challenges knowing that Allah (s.w.t) is there to guide us."

The siege reinforced for Mambuay the urgent necessity of her work. The violent extremism that destroyed her hometown represented the antithesis of everything she advocated—connection instead of division, empathy instead of hatred, dialogue instead of violence. In the years following the siege, her efforts to promote understanding, reduce prejudice, and equip young people with communication skills took on even greater significance.

Recognition and Awards

In recognition of their collective family advocacy for interfaith peace and unity, Mambuay and her family received the prestigious Jollibee Family Values Award. The Jollibee Family Values Awards, initiated by the Philippines' leading fast-food chain, honor Filipino families who exemplify positive values and make significant contributions to their communities through various advocacies.

The award recognized the Mambuay family's noble work in seeking peaceful ways to build unity between Christian and Muslim faiths. Jollibee honored them alongside other Filipino families from Luzon, Visayas, Mindanao, and the United States for their noteworthy advocacies that made significant impacts in the lives of their fellowmen. Winners received cash prizes, trophies designed by renowned brass sculptor Michael Cacnio, and public recognition at the Gabi ng Parangal para sa Pamilyang Pilipino (Night of Honor for Filipino Families).

The award highlighted how the family's work embodied core Filipino values—bayanihan (communal unity), malasakit (compassion), and pagkakaisa (solidarity)—while specifically addressing one of the most challenging divides in Philippine society: the Muslim-Christian relationship. The recognition brought greater visibility to their

work and validated their approach of starting with the family unit as the foundation for broader social transformation.

Beyond the Jollibee award, Mambuay's pioneering status as the Philippines' only CNVC-certified trainer has brought her international recognition within the global NVC community. She is listed on the Center for Nonviolent Communication's official website and has been featured in various NVC networks and publications. Her profile notes her mission: "to share NVC to people, both in groups and individuals to inspire and support them in giving and receiving from the heart & speaking and listening from the heart."

Personal Philosophy and Approach

Mambuay's work is grounded in several interconnected philosophical commitments. At the core is her belief that "connection is why we're here; it is what gives purpose and meaning to our lives"—a quote from researcher Brené Brown that Mambuay frequently cites. This emphasis on connection directly counters the forces of division, othering, and dehumanization that fuel conflict.

Her integration of NVC with Islamic spirituality offers a unique contribution to peacebuilding discourse. While NVC was developed by a secular Jewish psychologist primarily for Western contexts, Mambuay demonstrates how its principles align with Islamic teachings about compassion, justice, and the unity of humanity. She views NVC not merely as a communication technique but as "a way of life" that reflects spiritual values.

In interviews, Mambuay emphasizes that NVC is particularly liberating for interfaith work: "We can sit down together and share experiences, not looking at each other as Muslims or Christians but all as creations of one God. This is liberating, thanks to Nonviolent Communication." This framing allows participants to transcend identity-based divisions and connect at the level of shared humanity and shared needs.

Her approach to training emphasizes experiential learning over intellectual understanding. NVC workshops typically involve extensive role-playing, where participants practice empathic listening and honest expression in simulated difficult conversations. Exercises like "Four Chairs" (giving empathy to others) and "Four Ears" (receiving hard-to-hear messages) provide concrete skills for navigating real conflicts.

Mambuay also brings attention to the intersection of communication and power. She continually develops her skills in "integrating NVC to reduce prejudice and bias—particularly among people of different faiths and youth." This recognizes that communication patterns both reflect and reinforce social hierarchies, and that transforming these patterns requires addressing underlying prejudices and structural inequalities.

Family and Generational Transmission

Mambuay is married to Nathaniel Mambuay, also a Muslim-Maranao who shares her commitment to peacebuilding and nonviolent communication. Their partnership models the egalitarian, collaborative approach that NVC promotes, with both spouses actively engaged in advocacy work as equals.

The couple's children, including Lara Mambuay and Sarah Adrianne Mambuay, have also become NVC practitioners and facilitators. Lara co-facilitated the 2022 Interfaith Cooperation Forum Training of Trainers alongside her mother, while Sarah Adrianne led sessions on empathy exercises during the same training. This generational transmission ensures that the family's work will continue and demonstrates how NVC principles can be lived within family systems.

The children's involvement in community outreach from a young age—helping distribute slippers and school supplies, participating in feeding programs, engaging in interfaith activities—reflects the family's commitment to raising socially conscious, empathetic young people. As Mambuay noted, the Jollibee Family Values Award recognition made each family member "more enthusiastic and dedicated in involving themselves with the outreach programs we participate in."

The family's decision to run a shelter for both Muslim and Christian students further exemplifies their commitment to creating spaces of coexistence and mutual respect. Living alongside children from different faith backgrounds, the Mambuay children learned practically what their parents taught theoretically—that religious differences need not be barriers to friendship and solidarity.

Legacy and Continuing Impact

Amina T. Mambuay's legacy is multifaceted. As the Philippines' first and only internationally certified NVC trainer, she has pioneered the systematic teaching of empathic communication in a country where indirect communication styles and hierarchical social structures often make honest expression difficult. Her workshops have reached thousands of Filipinos across sectors—educators, religious leaders, youth, families, government officials, and community organizers.

Her particular contribution lies in demonstrating NVC's applicability to interfaith peacebuilding in contexts of entrenched conflict. While NVC is often taught as a tool for interpersonal relationships or workplace communication, Mambuay shows how it can address collective trauma, historical grievances, and identity-based conflicts. Her work proves that even in situations as complex and painful as Muslim-Christian relations in post-siege Mindanao, tools for empathy and understanding remain relevant and powerful.

As a Maranao woman, Mambuay also challenges stereotypes about Muslim women's roles and agency. In a context where Muslim women are often portrayed as passive or oppressed, she exemplifies active leadership, international engagement, and cross-cultural bridge-building. Her authority as a certified trainer and her partnerships with Catholic religious orders demonstrate her ability to command respect across gender and religious boundaries.

The institutional structures she has helped build—Kalilintad Pilipinas Inc., the network of NVC practitioners in the Philippines, the active Silsilah Forum chapters—provide infrastructure for ongoing peacebuilding work that will outlast any individual leader. By training other facilitators and creating systems of support, Mambuay ensures that the impact of her work multiplies beyond her direct reach.

Her life also offers testimony to the power of unlikely friendships and cross-boundary partnerships. That a nun gave her the book that changed her life, that a priest recommended her for international training, that German trainers traveled to the Philippines to support her certification—all these moments illustrate how peacebuilding requires people willing to transcend their own tribal loyalties and invest in others' flourishing.

Looking forward, Mambuay's work becomes ever more critical as the Philippines grapples with ongoing challenges around religious pluralism, violent extremism, historical injustice, and social cohesion. The tools and approaches she offers—empathic listening, honest expression, needs-based dialogue, conflict transformation—provide practical pathways toward the peaceful, just society that policy declarations and military operations alone cannot achieve.

In her own words, reflecting on NVC's significance: "It is not only a tool for peace building, it is a way of life." This simple statement captures the essence of Mambuay's contribution—she has spent decades not just talking about peace but embodying it, not just teaching communication skills but living them, not just hoping for understanding but systematically creating the conditions for it to emerge.

See Also

- Center for Nonviolent Communication
- Silsilah Dialogue Movement
- Marawi City
- Maranao people
- Interfaith dialogue in the Philippines
- 2017 Marawi siege
- Muslim Mindanao
- Nonviolent Communication

External Links

- Amina Mambuay - Center for Nonviolent Communication Official Trainer Page (https://www.cnvc.org/trainers/amina-mambuay)
- Silsilah Dialogue Movement Official Website (http://www.silsilahdialogue.com/)
- Amina Mambuay - NVC Rising Profile (https://www.nvcrising.org/people/amina-mambuay)
- Profile suggested by Shai Mambuay (https://www.facebook.com/shaimby.21)

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